Benedict Guttman-Kenney: Research Statement*

I am an Assistant Professor of Finance at Rice University, Jones Graduate School of Business. I hold a Ph.D. Economics & M.B.A. from the University of Chicago Booth School of Business, where I was awarded the NBER Dissertation Fellowship on Consumer Finance. My research focuses on household finance topics that are academically interesting and can also inform effective consumer financial protection regulation. Before my PhD, I worked for six years at the UK consumer financial protection regulator and was seconded to the Federal Reserve Bank of New York. These experiences provided me with deep institutional knowledge that informs my research.

My research spans the academic fields of household finance, behavioral economics/finance, and FinTech to learn about consumer and firm behaviors. I group my research into two broad topics: (1) the economics of credit information, and (2) behavioral household finance. A theme connecting these two topics is consumer repayment. My behavioral research studies the economics and psychology behind consumer borrowing and repayment choices. My credit information research studies how informative information about payments are for predicting consumer behaviors and how information sharing impacts credit access.

1 The Economics of Credit Information

My first research topic studies the role of credit bureaus in the financial system and the implications for consumers of different information being shared to be used in credit reports.

My paper, **"Consumer Credit Reporting Data"** (Gibbs et al., 2025), is published in the ***Journal of Economic Literature*** (a top general-interest economics journal). This paper describes the economics of consumer credit reporting data, highlights these data's uses across fields, and provides practical guidance on use.

In my working paper **"Unraveling Information Sharing in Consumer Credit Markets"** (Guttman-Kenney and Shahidinejad, 2026), provides the first empirical evidence of a breakdown of voluntary information sharing in consumer credit markets. Between 2013 and 2022, the sharing of actual payments information with US credit bureaus decreased by 53 percentage points for credit cards, but did not decrease for other products. Credit card lenders are responding to a credit bureau innovation that uses actual payments information to reveal heterogeneous credit card behaviors: spending that drives interchange revenue, and revolving debt that drives interest revenue. Lenders that stop sharing have more profitable, higher-spending portfolios; by not sharing, they limit competitors' ability to target these customers. Studying a prior mandate to share information on credit limits, I show results consistent with increased competition.

My solo-authored working paper, **"Credit Reporting Relief from Natural Disasters"** (Guttman-Kenney, 2026a), has a Revise & Resubmit at ***Management Science***. This paper studies the informativeness of delinquencies during natural disasters and a form of forbearance that operates purely through credit reports: "disaster flags". 68 million US consumers had a disaster flag between 2015

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and 2024. Flags mask adverse credit report data – separate to any changes to contract terms – aiming to protect credit access following disasters. I provide causal evidence that flags temporarily increase credit scores but, contrary to their aim, do not increase credit access, consistent with some lenders interpreting flags as a negative signal. I then quantify the equity-efficiency trade-off of a counterfactual policy automatically masking all delinquencies of consumers exposed to natural disasters: masking 2% to 33% of all delinquencies costs only 0.1% to 0.5% of predictive performance.

My working paper, **"Immigration and Credit in the United States"** (Cookson et al., 2026), studies how immigrants assimilate into US consumer credit markets, identifying immigrants from the timing of Social Security Number assignment. Immigrants are positively selected: although they arrive without a US credit history, their credit scores average 27 points higher than non-immigrants' by age 30, a difference that holds within five-digit ZIP codes and persists with age. Despite this, immigrants are 16 percentage points less likely to have ever had an auto loan, and 9 percentage points less likely a mortgage, by age 37. Comparing same-age immigrants arriving one year apart, I find lower credit access persisting more than a decade after immigration.

2 Behavioral Household Finance

My second research topic studies consumers' use of unsecured debt by combining big datasets with tools from economics and psychology. My paper, **"How Do Payday Loans Affect Borrowers? Evidence from the U.K. Market"** (Gathergood et al., 2019), is published in the ***Review of Financial Studies*** (one of the top three finance journals). Linking the population of UK payday loan applications to credit reports and using a Regression Discontinuity Design at credit score thresholds, I estimate that payday loan use causes short-run liquidity gains but persistent costs from defaults and overdraft use. This paper has over 100 citations.

In, **"Buy Now, Pay Later (BNPL) ...On Your Credit Card"** Guttman-Kenney et al. (2023), I published the first academic finance paper studying "buy now, pay later" (BNPL), documenting that consumers charge BNPL installments to their credit cards. This paper has over 200 citations. Given my expertize on BNPL, I was invited to write a review of the academic literature and the open policy issues (Guttman-Kenney and Zhang, 2026).

A key part of this agenda tests behaviorally-informed policies to help consumers reduce their credit card debt (Adams et al., 2022; Sakaguchi et al., 2022; Guttman-Kenney et al., 2025; Guttman-Kenney, 2026c; Allen et al., 2026). The first paper, **"Default Effects of Credit Card Minimum Payments"** (Sakaguchi et al., 2022), published in the ***Journal of Marketing Research***, shows the default effects of credit card minimum payments. The second paper, "Do Nudges Reduce Borrowing and Consumer Confusion in the Credit Card Market?" (Adams et al., 2022), solicited for the Centenary issue of ***Economica***, finds nudges are ineffective in field experiments on 180,000 consumers across three lenders. These two papers each have over 35 citations. The third paper from this project, **"The Semblance of Success in Nudging Consumers to Pay Down Credit Card**

Debt" (Guttman-Kenney et al., 2025), is published in the ***American Economic Journal: Economic Policy***, with over 50 citations.[1] This paper finds that, despite causing large changes in Autopay enrollment, a nudge tested in a field experiment does not reduce credit card debt due to offsetting consumer responses.

I understand why nudges fail to reduce credit card debt in my working paper, **"Targeting Higher Credit Card Payments"** (Guttman-Kenney, 2026c). In a pre-registered experiment, I find that a nudge to shroud the minimum payment on non-Autopay choices does not increase payments, and linked clickstream data reveal that consumers initially select *lower* amounts and exert effort to reveal the shrouded minimum, thus "hacking" the nudge. My results are inconsistent with an existing view, based on repeatedly-replicated online experiments, that consumers anchor on the minimum payment amount – implying that shrouding it would raise payments, a policy regulators have considered. Instead, I show that the minimum payment is not an irrelevant anchor but a relevant target: cardholders frequently lack liquid cash and aim to pay at least this amount. This reconciles why payments are insensitive to nudges yet sensitive to minimum payment increases, as I show in my next paper.

If consumers target the minimum payment, then raising the requirement may be expected to reduce debt. My working paper, **"Paying Off: Evaluating Credit Card Minimum Payment Requirements"** (Allen et al., 2026), tests this by evaluating a Quebec mandate raising credit card minimum payments to 5% of balances. Applying synthetic difference-in-differences to Canadian credit reporting data, I estimate revolving debt falls 26% in the long-run with borrowers repaying more than required by the policy without increasing defaults. Such results are consistent with reducing over-borrowing driven by behavioral biases. But this policy has costs: delinquencies rise and issuers ration credit forcing some involuntary deleveraging. The policy appears to be beneficial using a sufficient-statistics framework to evaluate the trade-offs.

In **"Dynamic Heuristics"** (Guttman-Kenney, 2026b), I am studying the elasticity of consumer budgeting heuristics: finding when gas prices increase, the use of a round-numbered expenditure heuristic (e.g., PQ = £20) declines and consumers make more trips to refuel.

3 Research Impact and Service

My research has over 675 Google Scholar citations (July 2026). My research papers are cited in the Wikipedia articles on credit cards and payday loans. I have presented my research at numerous conferences, including the National Bureau of Economic Research (NBER), American Economic Association, and Midwest Finance Association meetings. I have been invited to give seminars at the Federal Reserve Bank of New York, Federal Reserve Bank of Philadelphia, Federal Reserve Board, PUC-Chile, Supervisory Research Forum of US financial regulators, and Universidad de Chile, among others. I have received much media coverage including ***BBC News***, ***CNN***, ***The***

[1] Ham et al. (2026) show the *American Economic Journals* rank only below the long-established top five economics journals in their impact, and dominate their respective top field journals.

Financial Times, ***The New York Times***, ***NPR Marketplace***, ***The Wall Street Journal***, and ***Yahoo! Finance***. I have three short policy papers on the COVID-19 pandemic (Gathergood and Guttman-Kenney, 2021; Gathergood et al., 2021; Guttman-Kenney et al., 2022).

For service to the profession at Rice, I co-organize the finance seminars, interview prospective Ph.D students, and provide ad-hoc advice for Ph.D students, including job market preparation.

Beyond Rice, I serve academia more broadly. I have refereed over 40 papers, including at the American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, American Economic Journal: Economic Policy, Management Science, Journal of Finance, Journal of Financial Economics, the Review of Financial Studies. I have discussed many papers, including at the American Finance Association, Midwest Finance Association, and the Western Finance Association meetings. I serve on the Society for Financial Studies Cavalcade committee, and have evaluated National Science Foundation grants.

4 Contribution Statement

Guttman-Kenney (2026a,b,c) are solo authored research. It is the norm in economics and finance academia for the authorship of journal articles to be in alphabetical order, and this applies to most of my papers (Fuster et al., 2018; Gathergood et al., 2019; Gathergood and Guttman-Kenney, 2021; Gathergood et al., 2021; Allen et al., 2026; Cookson et al., 2026; Gibbs et al., 2025; Guttman-Kenney et al., 2022; Guttman-Kenney and Zhang, 2026); my contribution to these papers should be considered equal to my other co-authors. I was the project lead on Adams et al. (2022) and my Job Market Paper (Guttman-Kenney and Shahidinejad, 2026), though both also list authors alphabetically. In two of my papers (Guttman-Kenney et al., 2023, 2025), the authorship is non-alphabetical to signal that I was the project lead despite being junior. My contribution to Sakaguchi et al. (2022) exceeded an equal share, this paper has a non-standard author order as it resulted from the merger of two papers during journal review: (1) Sakaguchi, Stewart, and Gathergood (non-alphabetical based on the norm in psychology), and (2) Adams, Guttman-Kenney, Hayes, Hunt, and Stewart (alphabetical based on the norm in economics).

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